

Episode 186: *Mawaru Penguindrum* Colour Design Notes – Part 13

This year I'm working at Toei Animation for the first time in several years. I commute to the Oizumi studio almost daily, and my desk is on the 3rd floor. I take the stairs up to the 3rd floor. But something's strange. That climb is incredibly tiring. Why?

So I checked various things, and ah! There are many steps on the stairs!

The reason being this studio has extremely high ceilings on each floor. How high? High enough that you could easily build lofts on each floor if you wanted. So while it's a 3-storeys building, it's actually equivalent in height to a 4-storeys building!

Normally, stairs between floors in apartments and such have about 13 steps. So for a 3-storeys building, that's 26 steps. But at Oizumi Studio it's 22 steps per floor. Climbing to the 3rd floor exceeds 40 steps, which is equivalent to the 4th floor of a normal building.

Ah, so that's it! In other words, while climbing stairs thinking it's the 3rd floor, I'm actually forced to consume energy equivalent to moving up a 4-storeys building. Ugh, fearsome Toei Animation Oizumi Studio!

Now then.

Episode 11: "Finally You Have Noticed" Storeysboard/Ikuhara Kunihiko, Kaneko Shingo & Yamazaki Mitsue, Direction/Yamazaki Mitsue, Colour Direction/Otsuka Natsuko

Starting with the diary being stolen, the relationship between Shoma and Ringo gradually becomes strained. And Ringo, who decided to restart "Project M," again borrows the power of the mysterious frog to bewitch Tabuki. But Tabuki goes berserk! And failure. Yuri, who returns home, also shows her class difference. Returning home defeated, waiting for her are Himari and Shoma. Those feelings of helplessness are directed at Shoma, but... Such was Episode 11.

It's the unexpected frog episode again (laugh). This time's frog, as you can tell from the visuals, is female (laugh). Himehmare Frog. The colour design was completed by adding a ribbon and lipstick to Episode 7's Tamahomare Frog character, with some colour divisions and colour changes. Quite labour-saving. For the main storeys too, the science room's cut divisions - or rather the cuts themselves - we used several cuts from the previous use as-is, so people who had been watching would understand "Ah, it's the frog again! (laugh)" and we could show it simply without adding extra cuts. Skillfully reusing cuts from past episodes like this was done quite intentionally in *Mawaru Penguindrum*, connecting to labour savings and being very effective.

Speaking of frogs, the frog website screen on Ringo's laptop in the science room - all of that is the work of special effects and graphic design staff Yamada Kanako. The animation materials we prepared were just the frog image and laptop animation. Based on that and the storeysboard performance, she created that PC screen. Man, I was surprised when I saw the completed screen! I've asked Yamada for design work around ICU monitor screens appearing in later episodes and #1's erotic magazine creation. Oh, special effects for cooking cuts are mostly Yamada's work too.

And again this time, the nighttime bedroom (laugh). Learning from Episode 7's failure, I designed it slightly brighter. However, scene design created in advance on art boards actually changes considerably in appearance due to differences in actual cut layouts and animation shadow angles and areas. But it's the colour directors who skillfully adjust that. Right after that, when they close the bedroom door from outside and trap frog-Tabuki inside, the colour director skillfully created the colour handling for tension and comical expression.

Actually, Episode 11 is quite a favourite of mine.

I think "colour design" is the job of writing the "colour blueprint" for a storeys, and "colour direction" is what creates screens by facing actual animation with that blueprint in hand. So if it follows the blueprint, that's even enough, but whether the screen

becomes even better depends entirely on the colour director's ability. It's an episode where that was put together in a settled, good feeling.

Colour directors who approach their assigned episodes with their own plans create wonderful work.

Understanding the "blueprint" I provide, then adjusting the balance with actual animation, sometimes suggesting "How about something like this?" - since it's the colour director who actually faces the animation, having them think about various things like this is both pleasing and helpful. The two main colour directors we're asking for this time, Otsuka and Akimoto, are such colour directors. The goal is ultimately the same: "How to make it even a little better."

Now, up to the nighttime scene in front of the apartment where returning Ringo meets Himari and Shoma, it was the usual *Mawaru Penguindrum* colour usage, but just before the end, boom! Yes, our nickname "95 Train." That subway visual was by art director Akiyama. When we all gathered to check on my monitor, starting with the director, we all went "Ohhhhh!" (laugh). We got somewhat excited with a visual that felt like "It's coming!" (laugh). Only the director came back to his senses saying "Is this okay? This (sweat)" (laugh).

Anyway, since the shocking visual exceeded our imagination, creating colours to go with it was fun. Here I finally lifted the ban on the method of changing main line colours. In Episode 11, inside the 95 train, I made Princess's main lines red-toned. Meanwhile, Ringo, Shoma, and the penguins remained the usual black-toned. Here, since I wanted to differentiate the positions of Princess versus Ringo and the others, I only changed Princess. Also, the base for overall colour change was created to link with the redness of the "95" number. When considering special colour tones in such enclosed spaces, incorporating the most eye-catching colour used in that space is a technique I always use. This tends to settle well when finished.

Anyway, Episode 11 ends with a tension-filled cliffhanger of "What on earth is about to begin!?"

(12.07.03)